

Anyone having knowledge of the American business scene could cite countless other examples paralleling these random few that I have mentioned. All would further help

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to prove that when the really topflight businessman is at bay, he very often turns adversity and even impending calamity into victory.

I've encountered my share of adversity and reverses. I've spent fortunes drilling many thousands of feet into the ground at one time or another—to strike nothing but sand.

I've had other wells that cost other fortunes run dry or blow up and burn. I soon learned to accept such misfortunes philosophically and to take them in my stride, for I realized that I would not be able to stay in business very long if I permitted them to discourage me. In fact, each setback seemed to serve as a special incentive and stimulus to try again—but even harder the next time.

There were many other, more complex trials and blows, too. I recall, for example, the sharp break in crude-oil prices that occurred in 1921, when oil, which had been selling at \$3.50 per barrel, dropped to \$1.75 per barrel in less than 10

days—and the price continued to spiral down in the days that followed. At least one of the companies in which I held a substantial interest became hard-pressed for cash as a result of the price crisis.

When I met with other directors of the company, there were those among them who verged on panic. Fortunately, the majority remained calm and objective. Any suggestions that the company close its doors were immediately voted down. Instead, it was agreed to retrench and the directors agreed to obtain the money needed to keep the company going. They also agreed to slash their compensation to the bone and reduce management salaries until the crisis was past. In time, the petroleum market became stabilized once more—and as soon as conditions returned to normal, the directors and management implemented an ambitious pro-